

CATS



DOMESTIC CATS are related to wild cats, such as lions and tigers, and they are able to fend well for themselves. They are excellent

hunters, and their eyes, ears, nose, and whiskers are well adapted for their natural preference for hunting at night. Cats are affectionate and respond well to humans. They were domesticated about 4,000 years ago to keep people company and to destroy pests.



White



Lilac



Red



Blue



Chocolate



Siamese



British shorthair



Persian longhair



Devon Rex



Grooming

Cats are very clean animals and spend at least an hour a day grooming, using their tongue as a "comb". The tongue has tiny hard spines, called papillae, on its surface. The licking helps to keep the fur clean and waterproof, and also spreads the cat's scent all over its body.

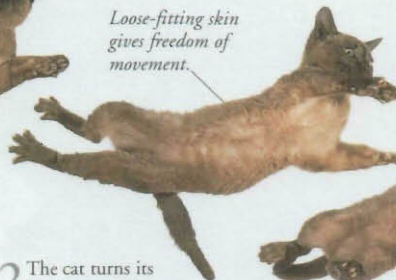


Papillae



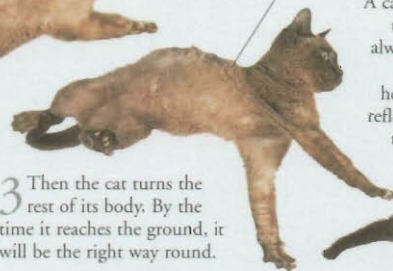
1 If a cat suddenly falls, balance organs in its ears tell it which way is up.

Loose-fitting skin gives freedom of movement.



2 The cat turns its head around first so that it can see where it is falling, and where it is going to land.

Flexible spine allows the cat to twist its body.



3 Then the cat turns the rest of its body. By the time it reaches the ground, it will be the right way round.

Games enable kittens to practise hunting skills, such as stalking and catching.



Balance

A cat's long flexible tail helps it to balance. Cats will almost always land on their feet, even when falling from a great height. They have very quick reflexes and can twist and turn their body the right way up in a fraction of a second.

Back paws are brought forward.



4 The cat stretches out its front legs to absorb the impact of landing.

Senses

Cats can see well in low light and can focus on small objects a long way away. Their super-sensitive hearing picks up sounds that we cannot hear and can also take in two sounds at once, such as a mouse in a thunderstorm. Whiskers are sensitive to touch. Cats use them to feel their way in the dark, and to measure whether spaces are wide enough for them to go through.



Narrow pupils in the light



Large pupils in the dark

Changing pupils

A cat's pupils expand enormously in the dark to let in as much light as possible. A layer of cells at the back of the eyes, called the tapetum, reflects light back into the eye which helps cats see in the dark.

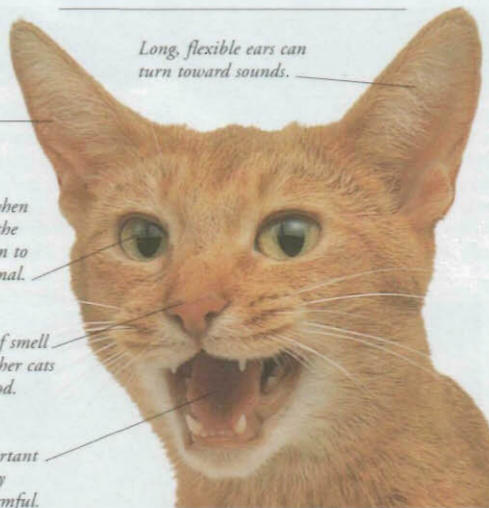
Ears are funnel-shaped to draw sounds inside the ear.

Cats rely more on eyesight than smell when hunting. They have the largest eyes in relation to their size of any animal.

Cats use their sense of smell to identify objects, other cats and animals, and food.

Sense of taste is important for distinguishing any food that may be harmful.

Long, flexible ears can turn toward sounds.



Claws

Cats use their claws to defend themselves and to climb. At other times, the claws are drawn in, or retracted, for protection. They are covered by a bony sheath that is an extension of the last bone of each toe and fit inside pockets in the skin.



FIND OUT
MORE

ANIMAL
BEHAVIOUR

EYES AND
SEEING

LIONS AND OTHER
WILD CATS

MAMMALS

MOUNTAIN
WILDLIFE